Dawson’s content design portfolio.

I design the systems behind product language: voice standards, tone boundaries, and workflows that help teams write clearly, consistently, and responsibly at scale.

Across these case studies, I focus less on individual lines of copy and more on the problems language is used to solve—navigating ambiguity, aligning stakeholders, managing risk, and translating complex ideas for diverse audiences. Much of this work lives upstream of the interface, where copy functions as infrastructure: a way to establish shared understanding before products, programs, or policies fully take shape.

The examples below reflect how I approach content as a design system—defined by constraints, documented decisions, and repeatable processes—rather than as one-off writing exercises.

NOTE ON STYLE GUIDE SAMPLES
I’ve also authored and maintained internal voice and style guides used by multiple teams; I’m happy to share excerpts or walk through them during interviews.

Case Study: Establishing a Trustworthy Voice for a New Community Program

Oracle Luminaries, a developer community

CONTEXT

This program launched under evolving organizational conditions, requiring careful tone calibration to avoid overpromising or misalignment.

Luminaries was an ultimately aborted developer group for Oracle users seeking troubleshooting support, virtual/IRL community, and career investment through badges and discounted certification. Its current status is up in the air. Signs point to it being subsumed into Oracle’s ACEs program.

Because this was a new program, a new voice was needed. That voice would be used for eBlasts, Slack blocks and tweets, in addition to blogs and an Eloqua registration page.

TASK: Voice Goals and Constraints

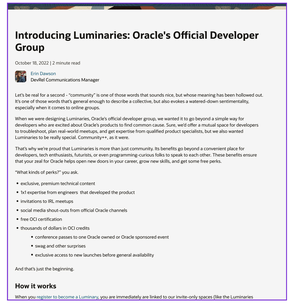
The task was to create a voice that was, on one hand, confident and resolute about the program’s benefits, and on the other, imparted sincere joy about how much the potential registrant would gain from this community.

ACTION: System, Rollout, and Decisions

Luminaries Blog post

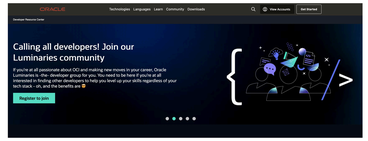
I first fleshed out this voice most when writing the blog. Using my own feelings about the word “community” and the quasi-corporate tone of a professional developer group, the blog is a frank document that drives toward its CTA of registration. Its air is one of “I know you’ve heard something like this before, but this time it’s different” without being too gimmicky.

In the blog, I used a collective “we” to emphasize community on both ends of this equation - the community that this program sought to create and the community of real human beings behind the design of Luminaries. I also used some subtle developer dog whistling with “Community++.”



Webcopy and Registration page

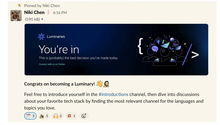
The developer.oracle carousel copy and registration page continue in this vein by using a tone that makes joining this community a common sense decision for career minded developers.



I’ve included a third screenshot (“There’s nothing artificial about this intelligence”) that also captures a similar tone. Though not Luminaries copy, I’m using the copy that I’ve written elsewhere as a guide for the Luminaries voice.

Slack block

Here again, I’ve flexed the kind of bravada needed for aspiring confidence in a new community. The CTA begins with a verb, “Connect,” that also evokes community (as in, more community awaits when you connect).



RESULTS

Due to the stalling of development and inclusion into the ACEs program, it’s difficult to say how successful this copy was relative to how successful we would have been if this program received buy-in from leadership.

Less objectively speaking, I do believe this tone to be a good fit for a new program like this. The confidence and frankness of this voice seemed necessary given Oracle’s (continued) mixed messaging regarding exactly how important developer communities are to them. That confidence was built in to reassure Oracle developers that we wouldn’t drop the ball this time.

WHAT WOULD I CHANGE?

The webcopy/carousel copy is the weakest here, in retrospect. Emoji looks out of place in hero copy. It doesn’t explain what benefits a developer would enjoy from joining the group and doesn’t leverage illumination imagery, which seems like a missed opportunity (though if memory serves, we tried a bit of that and it didn’t feel at home with the tone).

Case Study: Establishing a Playful Product Voice Without Undermining Trust

Pi Day 2022

CONTEXT

This event, facilitated by the DevRel team, used the 3/14 date as a way to engage developers for a day of labs and demos. Stakeholders requested an energetic, playful, and colorful tone which would lean into modern notions of internet absurdity and lighthearted nerdery.

CONSTRAINTS AND GOALS

The task was to create a voice that increased developer engagement through event registration. That voice was to strike an inviting confidence without any hint of a sales pitch. After establishing that voice, the task was to write web copy, social posts, social tiles, blog posts, and even a brief comedic sketch.

SYSTEM AND DECISIONS

While collaborating with the Brand team, primarily Ethan Johnson and Andre Martin, I wanted to combine technical language with notions of world building and fantasy, which would ideally trigger developers’ love for gaming. “AI wizards, check your wand at the door” evoked, perhaps, trainees studying AI, preparing to enter a lesson, laying down their wands to listen to a (pointy-hatted) sage and engage with the craft further.

While looking for tonal inspiration, I did a little research and found that Pi was an irrational number. After learning this, I wrote “Let’s make some irrational decisions together.” Though it’s difficult to trace the lineage of inspiration, I like to think that this line gave us the emotional permission needed to “get weird,” as it were.

Though it’s not a “traditional” copywriting deliverable, I wrote a Pi Day sketch for the DevRel team based on the telephone game, in which a message is increasingly garbled as it is retold.

My thinking was to make event information entertaining by parceling it out with new faces and interspersed by facts that have nothing to do with the event. The sketch ends with Bo telling us there won’t be pie at the event. I wrote the script, recruited participants, and gathered footage for the video content team to edit.

Their editing rendered these exchanges using a look similar to FaceTime, emphasizing the “telephone” in the telephone game bit.

RESULT

Pi Day was our most successful event of 2022. See the “External Channels” heading in the internal debrief of the event for numbers relevant to social copy.

As an aside, I did name the character of Razzy (whose spelling I don’t think has been codified yet). It looks like this character will be used for events this year, 2023, as well.

Case Study: Defining Product Messaging Under Organizational Ambiguity

Oracle DevWeek

CONTEXT AND UNCERTAINTY

This project launched without clear requirements, timelines, or final positioning, requiring copy to function as a sense-making tool.

The details of this currently ongoing project have been opaque. From copy deliverables to messaging, leadership has been slow to provide requirements. In the meantime, I’m creating an angle that I hope will be adopted towards what we do know we’ll need - tweets, blogs, carousel messaging, social tiles, etc.

GOALS AND CONSTRAINTS

The task here is to (1) navigate ambiguity and (2) find an angle of overall messaging that resonates with my stakeholders (many people, though primarily Caroline Caldwell).

In my experience, even if it doesn’t go anywhere, starting a conversation with a draft elicits reactions and it’s from there you can start to focus on what The Ask is.

MESSAGING SYSTEM AND DECISIONS

Rather than waiting for finalized requirements, I used draft copy to surface assumptions, test tone, and align stakeholders.

The DevWeek event uses Oracle’s “corporate” voice, which deemphasizes playfulness, so this event does not call for a unique or clever voice. Using a tone that spins away from irreverence and maximizes clarity using plain language, I want to leverage the real-world, material threats that are currently a reality to developers.

That means acknowledging economic conditions which translate into threats of layoffs. But doing so in a way that isn’t too scary. This isn’t playful, this isn’t clever - this event is a time of focus and a time to rediscover the very thing you fell in love with in the first place: building things with code (read: development).

A note - I did not write the day descriptions. Reps from those teams submitted their own copy.

RESULT
While final messaging was still evolving, early drafts successfully aligned stakeholders around a more grounded, developer-first narrative.

Preliminary discussions with stakeholders pointed towards buy-in regarding the angle of homecoming for developers - getting back to their roots and focusing on what they love.

WHAT WOULD I CHANGE?

I’m of two minds about the exclamation marks at the end of this blog post. On one hand, this is a CTA for an in-person event and that truly is exciting. On the other, I worry that this attitude doesn’t match the cold-splash-of-water-in-the-face with which the entry begins.

Case Study: Managing Accuracy, Tone, and Trust in Developer-Facing Content

Customer Success Story, Cohere AI (link to story)

CONTEXT & RISK SURFACE
This work involved high technical and reputational risk, requiring strict accuracy, validation, and tone controls.

As part of Oracle’s Product Marketing team, I supported a shift from marketing Oracle Cloud Infrastructure to developers and enterprise audiences to marketing Oracle’s AI offerings, including Oracle’s AI coding companion and its graphics processing units (GPUs).

GOALS AND CONSTRAINTS
Part of the focus-shift from OCI to AI meant that Oracle needed to use all the arrows in its quiver to pivot its identity as not just the company known for database, Java, and ERP services, but one that empowers customers to do those things and more with the added power of AI.

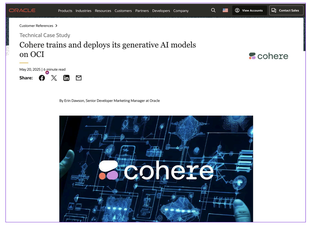
Technical Customer success stories are one of those arrows in that quiver.

This meant that I needed to write a customer success story demonstrating that Oracle is not just positioned to help organizations level up with AI, but that we can also help them transition to use Oracle’s GPUs which AI companies use to train their LLMs.

CONTENT SYSTEM AND VALIDATION WORKFLOW
I treated this deliverable as a governed content system, not a one-off piece.

One of these customer success stories highlighted Cohere, an AI platform, which used two Oracle products to train their LLM — Oracle Kubernetes Engine (OKE) and Oracle’s GPUs. For this story, we chose to highlight Cohere’s benefitting from Oracle’s GPUs and how easy the transition to using our services was.

The process for writing this deliverable meant working cross-collaboratively: technical experts on Oracle’s side were invited to the interviews I had with Cohere to fact check the deeply technical aspects of Cohere’s usage of Oracle’s services and fact-check, yours truly to interview the customer, Cohere’s engineers, and their subject matter expert (SME) who managed their end of this collaboration, providing ultimate signoff for what they did and did not want published.



RESULT
Over approximately three months, I worked with Cohere, Oracle’s engineers, and my organization’s leadership to arrive at a draft all parties were comfortable with.

This technical case study was published on Oracle.com, posted to LinkedIn on the Oracle Developers page, and reposted by Cohere.

WHAT WOULD I CHANGE?
Nothing here strikes me as needing overhauled. The piece combines approachable tone with highly technical information which does not come off as commercial. It also uses quotes from experts to provide additional legitimacy and a softening human element, which I find helps in a piece of this length and technical specificity. “In future iterations, these validation steps could be formalized into reusable documentation or tooling to support similar stories